

## *A Seeming Change: Quasimorph and the Critique of Anarcho-Capitalism*

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Abstract: This article examines how *Quasimorph*, a turn-based roguelike extraction shooter, models and critiques anarcho-capitalism through its narrative, worldbuilding, mechanics and economic systems. Anarcho-capitalism is a political and economic philosophy which envisions a stateless society based upon private property and voluntary contractual exchange within unfettered free-market competition – capitalism, without the state. Traditionally state-performed services (policing, defence, administering justice, etc.) would instead be performed by private companies competing for profit. *Quasimorph* offers a speculative, futuristic vision of anarcho-capitalism in practise in a colonized solar system. The game offers a powerful critique of anarcho-capitalist thought which, on three distinct fronts, shows that anarcho-capitalism would represent only a ‘seeming change’ from capitalism that would preserve and exacerbate its worst aspects. This paper shows how *Quasimorph* put this critique in playable form, affirming the video game’s status as a vehicle for the critique of social and political ideologies.

Keywords: Game Studies / Procedural Rhetoric / Political Philosophy / Political Economy / Libertarianism / Anarcho-Capitalism / Anarchism / Capitalism / *Quasimorph* / Roguelike

It is easier to imagine the end of the world than the end of capitalism.

- Mark Fisher, *Capitalist Realism*

When the apocalypse came, we shrugged our shoulders, and started profiting from it as usual.

- *Quasimorph*, Opening Monologue

### Introduction

Digital games have long been fertile sites for the exploration, affirmation, and critique of political ideologies, modelling complex sociopolitical imaginaries that invite players to inhabit, contest, or reproduce their internal logics. This article shows how Magnum Scriptum’s turn-

based, roguelike extraction shooter RPG *Quasimorph*<sup>1</sup> extends this tradition by offering a critique of *anarcho-capitalism* through its speculative, futuristic envisioning of an explicitly anarcho-capitalist world, where the state has been abolished but private property and unfettered capitalist competition and accumulation have been preserved. Despite anarcho-capitalism's marginal position in mainstream political theory, its assumptions (about state coercion, market freedom, private security, and private property) have been highly influential in the collective imaginations of Silicon Valley, crypto-libertarian movements, various technocratic utopianisms, and right-wing politics more broadly. It is worth sustained critical engagement because it represents a logical extreme of the libertarian tradition, combining a radical defence of private property and free exchange with the complete abolition of the state. As such, it functions as a useful limit case for testing claims about the necessity of public institutions for the provision of security, justice, and public goods – as well as the limits of 'free-market' capitalism. It still has advocates and adherents even though it was theoretically outlined over 50 years ago<sup>2</sup>, and its influence extends beyond political philosophy into popular culture and interactive media. Many video games, from corporate dystopias to space-trading simulations, implicitly model anarcho-capitalist worlds or ideas, whether to endorse or criticise them. Engaging with anarcho-capitalism even from a critical standpoint helps clarify the theoretical stakes of property rights, coercion, and monopoly - issues central to understanding the political economies of both real-world digital markets and their fictional analogues.

Through its narrative, worldbuilding and 'procedural rhetoric', which Ian Bogost famously defined as "the art of persuasion through rule-based representations and interactions"<sup>3</sup>, *Quasimorph* offers a powerful critique of anarcho-capitalism. By situating the player in an anarcho-capitalist economy and challenging them to survive in it, *Quasimorph* makes its internal structures and tensions playable, depicting anarcho-capitalism not as an aspirational utopia but a catastrophic, solar-system-wide order that collapses its own philosophical

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<sup>1</sup> *Quasimorph*. Developed by Magnum Scriptum. Published by HypeTrain Digital. Early access October 2<sup>nd</sup> 2023. 0.9.8 at time of writing (November 28<sup>th</sup> 2025). <https://store.steampowered.com/app/2059170/Quasimorph/>

<sup>2</sup> It is hard to quantify, but online forums and discussion pages indicate a sustained interest in anarcho-capitalist ideas among the public. The 'Anarcho\_Capitalism' Reddit page, for instance, has 193 thousand followers.

<sup>3</sup> Bogost, I. *Persuasive Games: The Expressive Power of Videogames*. The MIT Press. Massachusetts. 2007. p. ix

premises. While the game features rich narrative worldbuilding, its most incisive critique arguably emerges through play. The player's labour, risk, reward, equipment, and progression, are structurally shaped by an economy designed to model the 'pure' free-market incentives of an anarcho-capitalist economy. Through this, *Quasimorph* shows that anarcho-capitalism does not transcend capitalism's inequalities and injustices, but intensifies them. State power is not eliminated but redistributed into a decentralised patchwork of private coercive regimes, forfeiting any claim of this order to being genuinely anarchistic. There is no such thing as a perfectly free, non-coercive market – even when freed from state intervention. Market forces do not naturally prevent power asymmetry and domination, but give rise to them. The unregulated market does not naturally guard against monopolies, but more easily facilitates their creation by those with the most might and capital. Ultimately, I argue that, as suggested by its title, *Quasimorph* reveals anarcho-capitalism precisely as a 'quasi-morph': only a 'seeming change' from state capitalism which preserves its structural logic while intensifying its most harmful tendencies. In doing so, this article expands existing accounts of libertarian ideology in games by addressing a more radical branch, while contributing to debates on the limits and possibilities of procedural rhetoric. It affirms the critical capacities of digital games as ideological laboratories, virtual spaces where political visions can not only be imagined but tested, stressed, and exposed through the logics of play.

### Libertarian Imaginaries in Digital Games

*Anarcho-capitalism*, the primary target of *Quasimorph*'s critique, is a political and economic philosophy taking the form of a marginal, radical strain of *libertarianism*. As van der Vossen and Christmas put it, "libertarians take individual freedom as the paramount political value and understand coercion to be the antithesis of that freedom."<sup>4</sup> Because "rights of freedom of contract and exchange, freedom of occupation, private property, and the like are taken very seriously [...] libertarians [...] oppose most forms of economic regulation, licensing laws, and redistributive taxation."<sup>5</sup> There is significant internal disagreement among libertarians about

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<sup>4</sup> van der Vossen, B. and Christmas, B. 'Libertarianism'. *The Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*. 2023. (Winter 2024 Edition) Edward N. Zalta & Uri Nodelman (eds.) <<https://plato.stanford.edu/archives/win2024/entries/libertarianism/>>.

<sup>5</sup> van der Vossen, B. 'Libertarianism.' *Oxford Research Encyclopedia of Politics*. 2017. Accessed 13 Aug. 2025. <https://oxfordre.com/politics/view/10.1093/acrefore/9780190228637.001.0001/acrefore-9780190228637-e-86>.

how best to maximize freedom and what the correct nature and extent of state intervention is, such that libertarianism could be described, in Virkkala's terminology, as "a range of opinion about the proper limitations of coercion in society."<sup>6</sup>

This range is sometimes presented as a spectrum of 'left' and 'right' varieties. 'Left-libertarian' visions of society tend to "insist [...] on some version of joint or collective ownership of the external world [...] [where] freedom is qualified in ways that preserves some degree of equality."<sup>7</sup> 'Right-libertarians', however, are often "more comfortable with actually-existing economic inequality as it exists under most capitalist systems, taking it to be an approximation of that which would occur in a truly free market." (van der Vossen/Christmas 2023) Right-libertarians typically defend some version of free-market capitalism as conducive to human freedom and argue that the role of the state should be "the enforcement of a system of rights that facilitate socioeconomic cooperation, and little else." (van der Vossen/Christmas 2023) Anarcho-capitalism is right-libertarianism taken to its extreme logical conclusion, as Holcombe concisely summarizes: "everything the government does, the market can do better, and therefore the government should be eliminated completely."<sup>8</sup> While libertarianism has received substantial attention in game studies, anarcho-capitalism itself arguably remains understudied. Its specific commitments - abolition of the state, privatisation of public services, the non-aggression principle, and the belief that free markets naturally prevent coercion and monopoly-formation - have not been thoroughly analysed in relation to game mechanics. *Quasimorph* offers an excellent opportunity to address this gap because it presents an ideological system not only through its narrative but by building it into the material logic of its gameplay.

Perhaps because of their emphasis on agency, competition, individual skill, and systems that reward maximising self-interest, digital games have often drawn inspiration from

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<sup>6</sup> Virkkala, T. 'Contra Sabatini: Bogus Critique.' *Ozarkia*. Accessed August 14<sup>th</sup>, 2025. <http://www.ozarkia.net/bill/anarchism/library/VirkkalaBC.html>

<sup>7</sup> van der Vossen, B. 'Libertarianism.' *Oxford Research Encyclopedia of Politics*. 2017. Accessed 13 Aug. 2025. <https://oxfordre.com/politics/view/10.1093/acrefore/9780190228637.001.0001/acrefore-9780190228637-e-86>.

<sup>8</sup> Holcombe, R. G. 'Government: Unnecessary but Inevitable.' *The Independent Review*. Vol. 8, no. 3, Winter 2004, ISSN 1086-1653, pp. 325–342. p. 326

libertarianism. Libertarianism constitutes a ‘social imaginary’, a term often used in the humanities to discuss the various collective repositories of values, institutions, laws, symbols, and images through which the people imagine their coexistence. As Charles Taylor puts it in his important formulation, the social imaginary concerns

the ways people imagine their social existence, how they fit together with others, how things go on between them and their fellows, the expectations that are normally met, and the deeper normative notions and images that underlie these expectations. [...] [these are] often not expressed in theoretical terms, but [are] carried in images, stories, and legends.<sup>9</sup>

Digital games are now a prominent component of humanity’s social imagination and often draw on ideas from libertarian imaginations of society in designing their worlds and narratives. *Deus Ex*, *The Outer Worlds* and *Cyberpunk 2077* all take place in worlds where capitalism has been allowed to run unchecked, with corporations allowed to operate as they please in pursuit of wealth and power – and they’re far from alone in choosing this ‘corporate dystopia’ narrative backdrop. A number of science-fiction games have modelled political systems that resonate with libertarian fantasies, such as *EVE Online*’s player-run corporations that compete for resources and profit, *Starsector*’s intergalactic patchwork of competing commercial powers, and *Elite Dangerous*’s laissez-faire frontier capitalism. These games present worlds in which state absence or weakness allows private entities to become the arbiters of order, security, and justice, all of which resonates with the central tenets of anarcho-capitalist thought.

Other games have gone further in the critique of specific formulations of libertarian ideology, with one of the paradigmatic and most well-documented cases being *Bioshock*.<sup>10</sup> The ideology of *Bioshock*’s world of ‘Rapture’ and its founder Andrew Ryan are, as Shaw correctly says, “libertarian in the extreme”<sup>11</sup> and clearly modelled on Ayn Rand’s ‘objectivism’: a radically individualist and capitalist brand of right-libertarianism that has had notable influence on the

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<sup>9</sup> Taylor, C. *Modern Social Imaginaries*. Duke University Press. London/Durham. 2004. p. 23

<sup>10</sup> *Bioshock*. 2K. 2007.

<sup>11</sup> Shaw, D. O. ‘Ideology in *Bioshock*: A Critical Analysis.’ *Press Start Journal*. Vol. 5, Issue 1. p. 83. <https://press-start.gla.ac.uk/press-start/article/view/77>

American right.<sup>12</sup> As Murnane explains, “Rapture *is* a version of Galt’s Gulch”<sup>13</sup>: the libertarian entrepreneurial utopia described in Rand’s *Atlas Shrugged* as “not a state [...] just a voluntary association held together by nothing but every man’s self-interest.”<sup>14</sup> Both Shaw and Murnane discuss how *Bioshock* interrogates Rand’s political philosophy by showing how her “imagined utopia becomes dystopian” (Murnane 2018, 146), collapsing into chaos, brutality and civil war, “brought low by human avarice and arrogance” (Shaw 2019, 86). *Bioshock* represents a case of a game engaging in a concerted, sophisticated critique of a clearly identifiable type of libertarian ideology which exposes its inner contradictions and dangers by putting them in playable narrative form.

In this respect, *Quasimorph* shares a deep affinity with *Bioshock*. *Quasimorph*’s world is explicitly modelled on a clearly identifiable form of right-libertarianism – its most extreme form, anarcho-capitalism. It shows how, if implemented on a grand scale according to its own conception and principles, anarcho-capitalism would collapse into a hellish dystopia, echoing Noam Chomsky’s claim that “anarcho-capitalism [...] if ever implemented, would lead to forms of tyranny and oppression that have few counterparts in human history.”<sup>15</sup> Where *Quasimorph* differs from *Bioshock* is in the scale and method of its critique. Rather than putting it in the form of a linear FPS narrative and localizing it to one context, *Quasimorph* operationalizes anarcho-capitalism on a solar-system-wide scale and enacts a procedural critique through open-ended gameplay.

### *Quasimorph*’s Procedural Rhetoric

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<sup>12</sup> Prominent US politicians and political figures that have publicly cited Ayn Rand as an inspiration include: president Donald Trump, the former speaker of the house Paul Ryan, the former congressman Ron Paul, senators Ted Cruz, Rand Paul, and Ron Johnson, the former CIA director and Secretary of State Mike Pompeo, the former secretary of state Rex Tillerson, and the Supreme Court Justice Clarence Thomas.

<sup>13</sup> Murnane, B. *Ayn Rand and the Posthuman: The Mind-Made Future*. Palgrave Macmillan. Cham, Switzerland. 2018. p. 145.

<sup>14</sup> Rand, A. *Atlas Shrugged*. New York: Signet, 1957. p. 695

<sup>15</sup> Chomsky, N. *On Anarchism: Noam Chomsky Interviewed by Tom Lane*. Chomsky.info. 1996. Accessed August 13<sup>th</sup>, 2025. <https://chomsky.info/19961223/>

To understand how *Quasimorph* performs its ideological critique, we turn now to *procedural rhetoric*: Ian Bogost's influential concept denoting the persuasive power of rules and systems, defined as

the art of persuasion through rule-based representations and interactions rather than the spoken word, writing, images, or moving pictures. [...] videogames can also disrupt and change fundamental attitudes and beliefs about the world, leading to potentially significant long-term social change.

(Bogost 2007, ix)

According to Bogost, digital games make arguments not only through narrative, but through the skilful deployment and interaction of their rule-based systems and mechanics, and the behaviours they require, reward, and punish. A system of game mechanics can model political or social processes and encourage players either to internalise or interrogate their logics. *Quasimorph* reveals anarcho-capitalism's inner contradictions and tensions through its worldbuilding and procedural rhetoric, which invite the player to inhabit them in gameplay, where their actions are structured by mechanics intended to model an anarcho-capitalist order.

Procedural rhetoric is not without its critics. As Skolnik correctly points out, part of the underlying philosophical and cultural significance of procedural rhetoric is that it responds to "the issue of where a game's meaning is situated"<sup>16</sup>, and on a strong interpretation would seem to suggest that it is principally situated in the formal structure of the game itself. As Miguel Sicart's *Against Procedurality* has forcefully argued, some strong interpretations of procedural rhetoric over-rely on proceduralism to the extent that the player's role (and the act of play itself) in the construction of meaning is marginalized or forgotten.

The assumption behind mainstream proceduralism is that the meaning of games is contained exclusively in the formal system of the game. [...] a game means what the rules mean, and understanding what games are is to understand what their rules describe. Players are important, but only as *activators* of the process that sets the meanings contained in the game in motion. The rules constitute the procedural argumentation of the game, and play is *just* an actualization of that process. [...] the meaning of a game comes from the meaning of following the rules.<sup>17</sup>

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<sup>16</sup> Skolnik, M. R. 'Strong and Weak Procedurality.' *The Journal of Gaming and Virtual Worlds*. Vol. 5, No. 2. 2013. pp. 147-163. p. 148

<sup>17</sup> Sicart, M. 'Against Procedurality.' *Game Studies*. Vol. 11, No. 3. 2011.

On such a strong reading of procedural rhetoric, whatever ethical or political message a game is trying to convey is already fully-formed in the game itself, just waiting to be discovered (exactly as the developer intended) by a player. But “without the player there are no ethics or politics, no values and no messages.” (Sicart 2011) Sicart’s approach is therefore more constructivist: player experience and engagement are the decisive factor in the construction of meaning, rather than the formal aspects of a game.

Skolnik is entirely correct in suggesting the existence of a “false dichotomy” of “procedural and constructivist approaches” (Skolnik 2013, 148) regarding the meaning of games which convey ideological messages. Instead, he proposes a spectrum between

*strong* and *weak* procedurality to clarify how a game’s structural context relates to the meaning it may generate for the player. Strongly procedural games are those in which design features converge in order to push the player towards procedural interpretation of a fixed authorial meaning. Weakly procedural games, by contrast, are those in which design features tend to lead to open game play styles, emergent behaviours and player-constructed meanings.

(Skolnik 2013, 148)

This is a useful distinction which can no doubt be mapped productively onto many games to clarify the ways their procedural systems generate meaning or lead to meaning being generated by players. However, as with much spectrum-based thinking, there will likely be limit cases that challenge the lines along which the spectrum is drawn, and *Quasimorph* represents such a case here.

In a sense, *Quasimorph* can be interpreted as a ‘strongly procedural’ game because its narrative, design features, and procedural systems do push the player towards an interpretation of a determinate ideological message. That message is encapsulated by the game’s title, which is a compound of ‘quasi’ and ‘morph’. According to the Cambridge English Dictionary, ‘quasi’ is “used to show that something is almost, but not completely, the thing described”<sup>18</sup> and ‘morph’

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<sup>18</sup> Cambridge English Dictionary. Entry for ‘quasi’. Accessed Oct 11<sup>th</sup>, 2025. <https://dictionary.cambridge.org/dictionary/english/quasi>



means “something [...] that has gradually changed from one thing to another.”<sup>19</sup> Therefore, the word ‘quasimorph’ (as well as referring to a fictional alien species in the game) is suggestive of *something that has only seemingly changed*, something which appears to have changed but has not in fact changed in essence. *Quasimorph* suggests that an anarcho-capitalist future would maintain all the inequalities and coercive hierarchies of capitalism while removing the limited protections afforded by democratic state structures, meaning that the world changes form but retains its underlying logic and structure, with all its worst aspects intensified. Anarcho-capitalism would represent only a seeming change from state capitalism: essentially the same thing, only much worse.

While this is the intended authorial meaning of *Quasimorph* that it guides the player towards and the correct way it should be interpreted, characterizing it solely as a strongly procedural game in Skolnik’s sense does it an injustice because it also resonates strongly with how he defines a ‘weakly procedural’ game. As an open-ended extraction-shooter roguelike set in a dynamic and reactive world economy, *Quasimorph* very much permits open gameplay styles and emergent behaviours, and enables player-constructed meanings to flourish. While it may have a strong procedural message that it guides players towards, it guides them with such a weak hand and light touch that it resists easily being characterized as a strongly procedural game. Its critique of anarcho-capitalism emerges through the emergent dynamics of play, framed by its narrative and worldbuilding. The game does not ‘tell’ the player that anarcho-capitalism is dysfunctional, confused, and would make the world a worse place, it places them within a vast system structured by its socioeconomic logic and asks them to survive in it. The critique of anarcho-capitalism is then discovered through player experimentation and their attempts to survive in *Quasimorph*’s world economy. There are various potential play styles and tactics that can lead to success, but all of them involve navigating the economy in ways that undermine anarcho-capitalism’s philosophical and economic assumptions.

In what follows, I will show that there are at least three central, distinct lines of critique of anarcho-capitalism to be found in *Quasimorph*, concerning

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<sup>19</sup> Cambridge English Dictionary. Entry for ‘morph’. Accessed Oct 11<sup>th</sup>, 2025. <https://dictionary.cambridge.org/dictionary/english/morph>

- 1) *The impossibility of free and non-coercive capitalist markets.*
- 2) *The inevitability of monopolies and asymmetric power dynamics under anarcho-capitalism.*
- 3) *The inevitable persistence of de facto state authority under anarcho-capitalism.*

In each case, the game undermines anarcho-capitalist assumptions by demonstrating how their operationalisation yields outcomes structurally identical to (or worse than) the capitalist systems they claim to transcend. Anarcho-capitalism's most prominent exponents claim that the freedom of the market from the state is paramount for the flourishing of human society, that a truly free market would morally and practically provide the best outcome for it, and that a free-market economy would provide natural checks and balances on power asymmetries, domination of particular groups by others, and monopoly-formation. *Quasimorph* undermines all of these claims, disputing the coherence of the idea of a free, non-coercive market, showing how power imbalances and domination would still persist under an anarcho-capitalist system, and showing how *de facto* state authority would continue under anarcho-capitalist conditions, rendering its status as actual anarchism null and void.

#### *Quasimorph's Anarcho-Capitalist World*

*Quasimorph* takes place 200 years in the future, where technology has advanced to the point where humanity has been able to colonize the solar system. It is a turn-based, roguelike extraction shooter RPG in which you run a Private Military Company (PMC) taking on contracts on behalf of powerful corporations. In terms of gameplay, it largely follows in the footsteps of *DRL* and its follow-ups *Jupiter Hell* and *Jupiter Hell Classic*, all roguelike homages to *Doom*. To this formula, *Quasimorph* adds an extraction mechanic in which you keep any loot and equipment gained on a mission, and lose it if you die. While its gameplay is engaging and mechanically well-constructed, far more interesting (in my view) is the explicitly anarcho-capitalist world and world economy that *Quasimorph* envisions which frames and provides context for the core gameplay loop. In it, the state has been abolished but the principles of private property and free-market capitalism have been preserved, with the solar system effectively being controlled by several corporations cooperating and competing with each other for profit, dominance, and the ongoing accumulation of capital. The corporations are ranked according to how much power and wealth they have, and how well-developed their technologies are, in a hierarchical economic system.

It bears emphasizing that *Quasimorph*'s engagement with anarcho-capitalist ideology is far from superficial, so it will help us to go into detail in what follows about what exactly anarcho-capitalism is, how it came to be, and what its core claims are. Anarcho-capitalism has historical roots in classical liberalism and the Austrian school of economics<sup>20</sup>, with its first presentation arguably being found in the work of the 19<sup>th</sup> century Belgian economist Gustave de Molinari.<sup>21</sup> But it only fully crystallized as a theoretical and ideological movement in the early 1970s, growing out of the increasing discontent with the failing Fordist-Keynesian economic consensus which emerged after World War II. The Fordist-Keynesian system consisted of a 'virtuous cycle' of mass organized production, high wages, and mass consumption coupled with high levels of economic intervention by the state, which would stabilize patterns of production and demand, ensure high employment levels, provide services, welfare, infrastructure, and so on. During the 1950s and 60s, this system resulted in a period of unprecedented economic growth and expansion in industrialized Western nations often referred to as the 'Postwar Boom'. However,

during the 1970s [...] its underlying crisis tendencies became more evident. The growth potential of mass production was gradually exhausted, and there was intensified working-class resistance to its alienating working conditions; the market for mass consumer durables became saturated; a declining profit rate coincided with stagflation; a fiscal crisis developed; internationalization made state economic management less effective; clients began to reject standardized, bureaucratic treatment in the welfare state; and American economic dominance and political hegemony were threatened by European and East Asian expansion. These phenomena prompted a wide-ranging search for solutions to the crisis of Fordism.<sup>22</sup>

The solution the world eventually settled on was neoliberalism, which "holds that a society's political and economic institutions should be robustly liberal and capitalist, but supplemented

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<sup>20</sup> Classical liberalism is a political philosophy rooted in Enlightenment thinkers like John Locke and Adam Smith, who emphasized the principles of individual liberty, rule of law, limited government, private property, and free markets. The Austrian School of Economics adhered to the principle of 'methodological individualism', holding that economic phenomena are best understood as the product of individual actions rather than abstract forces, and also argued for laissez-faire, free market capitalism and minimal state intervention, believing that such interventions disturbed natural market forces and caused economic crises.

<sup>21</sup> Molinari, G. *The Production of Security*. Trans. McCulloch, J. Ludwig von Mises Institute. 2009.

<sup>22</sup> *Britannica*. *Britannica Money*. Entry for 'Fordism'. Accessed January 8<sup>th</sup>, 2026. <https://www.britannica.com/money/Fordism>

by a constitutionally limited democracy and a modest welfare state.”<sup>23</sup> Another proposed solution, anarcho-capitalism, agreed with much of neoliberalism but went even further, conjecturing that the main cause of Western society’s economic problems was not just the high levels of state intervention in the market, but the very existence of the state itself. If the market were free of the state and allowed to get on with its business, the world would be a much better place. The principal proposition of anarcho-capitalism is therefore, exactly what it sounds like: capitalism without the state, right-libertarianism taken to its extreme logical conclusion.

It is arguably in the American economic theorists Murray Rothbard and David. P. Friedman that anarcho-capitalism received its seminal theoretical exposition. As Holcombe says, “Murray Rothbard has been the leading proponent” (Holcombe 2004, 327) of anarcho-capitalism, and it is with him and Friedman that it remains arguably most closely associated in political theory literature. In works like *For a New Liberty*<sup>24</sup> (1973) and *Man, Economy, and State*<sup>25</sup> (1962), Rothbard drew on moral principles and natural rights to make the case for anarcho-capitalist society as the one which would maximize the freedom of its people by best safeguarding humanity’s freedom and fundamental natural rights. Friedman, in *The Machinery of Freedom*<sup>26</sup> (1973), took a ‘consequentialist’ approach, claiming that anarcho-capitalist society would simply work better than any other kind of society and therefore would produce the best consequences for humanity.<sup>27</sup>

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<sup>23</sup> Vallier, K. ‘Neoliberalism’. In *The Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy* (Winter 2022 Edition), Edward N. Zalta & Uri Nodelman (eds.), URL = <<https://plato.stanford.edu/archives/win2022/entries/neoliberalism/>>

<sup>24</sup> Rothbard, M. *For a New Liberty: The Libertarian Manifesto*. 2<sup>nd</sup> edition. Ludwig von Mises Institute. Auburn, Alabama. 2006.

<sup>25</sup> Rothbard, M. *Man, Economy, and State: A Treatise on Economic Principles, with Power and Market: Government and the Economy*. 2<sup>nd</sup> edition Ludwig von Mises Institute. Auburn, Alabama. 2009.

<sup>26</sup> Friedman, D. P. *The Machinery of Freedom: Guide to a Radical Capitalism*. 3<sup>rd</sup> edition. Open Court Publishing. 2014.

<sup>27</sup> Friedman’s enthusiasm for the efficiency of the private sphere over the state is memorably encapsulated in what has become known as ‘Friedman’s Law’: “it costs any government at least twice as much to do anything as it costs anyone else.” (Friedman 2014, 82)

Rothbard's canonical presentation of anarcho-capitalism rejects the state outright as a structure of domination and coercion, positing four fundamental libertarian principles from which this view is derived:

- 1) The '*non-aggression axiom*': "no man or group of men may aggress against the person or property of anyone else." (Rothbard 2006, 27)
- 2) The '*right to self-ownership*': "the absolute right of each man [...] to 'own' his or her own body; that is, to control that body free of coercive interference." (Rothbard 2006, 33-34)
- 3) The '*absolute right to private property*': individuals have an absolute right to own the fruits of their labour, their homestead, and what they receive in free exchange. (Rothbard 2006, 28)
- 4) The '*right to free exchange*': the right to partake in "voluntary exchange and cooperation between freely acting individuals" (Rothbard 2006, 33)

If we hold these principles, then we must "regard the State as the supreme, the eternal, the best organized aggressor against the persons and property of the mass of the public." (Rothbard 2006, 56) States have engaged in all manner of criminality throughout history, including slavery, mass murder, domination, and theft of land and resources. Through military conscription, states have forced people to act contrary to their desires and best interests, and through taxation have parted them from their lawfully-earned money on threat of punishment. Rothbard and Friedman are in clear agreement here. Friedman calls state government "an agency of legitimized coercion" distinguished from a criminal gang only by its public recognition as legitimate. (Friedman 2014, 108) This language of criminality is echoed memorably by Rothbard: "only the government acquires its revenues through coercive violence. [...] If anyone but the government proceeded to 'tax', this would clearly be considered coercion and thinly disguised banditry." (Rothbard 2006, 30) For anarcho-capitalism, as for anarchism, the state is conceived of as an evil to be exorcised in the name of human emancipation. This it shares with classical anarchism, but diverges sharply from it in completely rejecting the communal ownership of property and endorsing the capitalist economic system as the best, most just, and most efficient way of organizing human life. Services traditionally performed by the state would be privatized, performed by private individuals or corporations for a profit, more cheaply, more fairly, and more efficiently than the state - up to and including security, defence, and policing. Police forces and militaries would be replaced by private security firms and mercenary groups, and courts by voluntary adjudication systems. Society would function according to voluntary contractual exchange

between free individuals pursuing their interests as they see fit in a free-market system unfettered by the coercive interventions of state power.

It is exactly this type of economic order that plays out in detail in *Quasimorph*, and from the ‘info’ pages of its various corporations, we can even glean some information about how it was established. It was borne of an event called the ‘Great Anarchist Revolution’, in which the weapons manufacturing corporation RealWare played a decisive role. The world’s governments descended into failure and corruption, leading to the dissolution of the ‘UN-2’ (presumably a futuristic version of the United Nations), widespread chaos, and a vacuum of power in the democratic state-capitalist system. Sensing an opportunity, RealWare “dropped thermonuclear charges on Geneva” (*Quasimorph* 2023) and initiated the armed revolution that would dissolve the world’s states and establish the ancap order, which consolidated itself as humanity ventured out from earth to colonize the rest of the solar system. Now a delicate balance of power reigns between the corporations as they try to out-do each other for profit and power while simultaneously needing to work with each other to preserve the new status quo that benefits them so much. The dissolution of governmental oversight and regulatory red tape allows the corporations to pursue their endeavours as they wish, leading to rapid expansion and profitmaking, sometimes at the cost of moral compromises. A good example here is the corporation Tianming, which “began life as an expansive biotech-industrial complex” operating in Asia, “one of [the] most controversial methods [of which] involves cloning living tissue for immediate conversion into bio-reactors that generate electricity.” (*Quasimorph* 2023)

While market power and capital has consolidated into a dozen or so corporations, there is still a power imbalance between the most powerful corporations and the least. Some of the corporations have considerably more power than others, which they maintain through skilfully manipulating their capital and availing themselves of the services of PMCs like yours in secret. In terms of what the various corporations actually do, the game’s minor corporations tend to excel at one service. Grasshopper Technologies specialize in transporting cargo, Coreward MG in mining, Daydream Chems in chemicals and pharmaceuticals, PlanetBridge in construction, Franche-Comte in prisons, and so on. The fact that the minor corporations provide a much-needed service ensures their continued survival in the market, but they lack the resources to diversify and further consolidate their power, so they remain relatively minor forces in the solar

system. Other minor economic players also include religious organizations (The Church of Revelation and Sunlight Coven) and the Civil Resistance: revolutionary ‘terrorists’ who challenge the ancap order. The major corporations, however, while each being dominant at something, “do not limit themselves only to their main focus” (*Quasimorph* 2023), investing in other areas such as security, education, or research, enabling them to strengthen, expand, and generally become more powerful than the minor corporations thanks to their greater resources. The major corporations include RealWare, AnCom (an ancap propaganda publisher, and research network), SBN (a media conglomerate which facilitates the flow of information throughout the solar system) and Dilthey (an engineering hyper-corporation used throughout the solar system).

*Quasimorph*’s corporations explicitly abide by the non-aggression principle: violence between them is absolutely forbidden. But this of course does not mean that it never happens. The absence of centralized systems of law and order creates space for the use and profitability of Private Military Companies (PMCs) such as the one you as the player are tasked with operating, who freely take on contracts with the corporations. Though not permitted to attack each other directly, the corporations routinely use PMCs to attack, sabotage, destabilize or otherwise gain advantage over their competitors. Since you are operating in secret on behalf of corporations that do not want to leave a trace of their dealings with you, you cannot be directly paid by them in the form of money. Instead, you receive ‘credit’ that is redeemable with them and them alone, which you can use to trade for their specific gear, as well as ammunition and other resources. Your actions as a PMC have a significant impact on the economy. When you attack a corporation on behalf of another, their positions in the economy are affected depending on whether they’re a victim or beneficiary of your violence, either rising or falling in the rankings accordingly. The higher a corporation’s ranking and your reputation with them, the better gear they will have available for you to purchase.

The additional layer given to the gameplay experience by the economy is arguably what makes *Quasimorph* such a compelling game and one of the more interesting traditional roguelikes in recent years. The economy is not just a gimmick that can be ignored. Navigating it and finding ways to exploit it is crucial for success, progression, and increasing in power. It quickly becomes apparent that concentrating your efforts on one or two corporations is a much more

efficient strategy than taking contracts from many, since you will more quickly build up their power and technological capabilities while simultaneously gaining more credit with them. If you split your time between several of the corporations, none of them will gain a significant advantage and you will not gain enough credit to buy anything of significance from any of them. The best way to ensure that you'll get better gear and enough resources to buy it is to favour one or two companies and set out to increase their standing, and your standing with them. This is an excellent place at which to start thinking about *Quasimorph's* actual criticism of anarcho-capitalism because it concerns the first of our three lines of critique, by problematizing the idea that an anarcho-capitalist market could be really be 'free'.

### *Quasimorph's* Unfree, Coercive Market

Anarcho-capitalism relies on the idea that society would be much better off if only we would rid the market of the coercive influence of the state and just let it get on with its business. As such, the idea of a beneficent 'free market' that would naturally improve human society is a crucial aspect of anarcho-capitalist thought. If there were no possibility of a genuinely free market to try and bring about, and if having one would be of no great benefit to human society, then anarcho-capitalism is already a non-starter. Rothbard defines the free market as "the network of free exchanges in society" (Rothbard 2009, 1024) and understands the consequences of such a system in a way that resonates beyond anarcho-capitalist thinking to right-libertarianism and neoliberalism more broadly. In a remarkable passage which distils so much about how these traditions conceive of the market, he claims that a free-market system produces

a delicate and even awe-inspiring mechanism of harmony, adjustment, and precision in allocating productive resources, deciding upon prices, and gently but swiftly guiding the economic system toward the greatest possible satisfaction of the desires of all the consumers. [...] not only does the free market *directly* benefit all parties and leave them free and uncoerced; it also creates a mighty and efficient instrument of social *order*.

(Rothbard 2009, 1024)

Anarcho-capitalism envisions a society bound together by a free-market system of voluntary contractual exchanges entered into freely by free agents to their mutual benefit, a system in which no one is coerced into doing anything they do not want to and which, when correctly established, would naturally bring about harmony, equality, and social order. The agency you



are afforded in *Quasimorph* parallels how individual agency is described in anarcho-capitalism: your work is structured around freely entered-into contracts between you and your employer. You are free within this system to choose who you work for and when, what kinds of contract you pursue, and their difficulty – with all parties involved acting without state interference in pursuit of their own self-interest. But *Quasimorph*'s anarcho-capitalist economy testifies that what Rothbard conjectures would happen in a free anarcho-capitalist market would not happen in reality, that such a market (because it would still be capitalist) would not really be free and uncoercive, would not directly benefit all parties, and would not naturally improve society by making it fairer and more orderly.

More on fairness and order later, but for now let's focus on the ideas of freedom and coercion. For Rothbard, in contrast to the free market, "coercion benefits one party only at the expense of others. Coerced exchange is a system of exploitation of man by man." (Rothbard 2009, 1025) Presumably, Rothbard has in mind state coercion and heavy-handed state interventions into the economy, but even if we removed the state from the picture, there are coercions inherent to any capitalist market system that would persist without the state. As David Harvey notes in line with Karl Marx, capitalism describes a system where "the class of wage labourers has been successfully deprived of access to the means of production and must, therefore, sell its labour power in order to live."<sup>28</sup> This is not something people have a choice in, and the same situation would persist under anarcho-capitalism. Coercion into selling one's labour power to survive is reflect in your positioning as the player in *Quasimorph*. You live a precarious existence on the fringes of the ancap economy, where the only means you have for survival is selling your labour power to corporations for credit to buy food, gear, and other resources. Your labour consists of exceedingly dangerous forays into corporate territories in which the lives of your mercenaries are constantly in danger and in which they have to inflict constant violence. What's more, the value you generate for the companies far exceeds what they are willing to compensate you in credit, especially if we take the level of danger of the work into account.

Such a life is not desirable, but the ancap system gives you no choice but to live it. And the same would be true in an anarcho-capitalist reality for many, with less extreme consequences.

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<sup>28</sup> Harvey, D. *Marx, Capital, and the Madness of Economic Reason*. Oxford University Press. Oxford. 2018. p. 7

Under anarcho-capitalism, people would be forced into jobs and contracts they do not want, which could well be unfavourable to them, just to get by. But the same is true of the system we have now – so what advantage do we get by removing the state from this equation? We would have a similar system to the one we have now, only more unfair and with less of a safety net for the most unfortunate in society. There would be no welfare system to fall back on if you were not able to find work, no public healthcare, no state programs whatsoever to help if the free-market system were to fail you, as it fails so many. All of these services could be afforded privately, but what would the incentive be for private firms to provide these services if there were no clear economic return to be had? Why would a private company provide healthcare or welfare services to people without the means to pay for them?

Essentially, *Quasimorph*'s positioning of the player problematizes the idea that there could exist a genuinely free and uncoercive capitalist market – state, or no state. The Rethinking Economics group puts its point well: “the free market doesn’t exist. Every market has some rules and boundaries that restrict freedom of choice. A market looks free only because we so unconditionally accept its underlying restrictions that we fail to see them.”<sup>29</sup> Every market is subject to (implicit and explicit) restrictions that inhibit particular choices while forcing others. We are given what Slavoj Žižek has called ‘false freedom’ or ‘the freedom of a false choice’.<sup>30</sup> I am free to sell my labour to survive, but I am also forced to sell my labour to survive. And the natural inequalities that such a system would produce actively forecloses me from pursuing courses of action I may want to pursue – like better, less dangerous, or precarious work. An anarcho-capitalist market would still be a capitalist market, and it is unlikely things would be different in this regard simply because there were no state. Ultimately, *Quasimorph* seems to concur with Sven Beckert’s assessment: “the “free market” [...] [is] nothing more than a figment of scholars’ and ideologues’ imaginations [...] appealing for its seeming ability to make sense of economic life.”<sup>31</sup>

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<sup>29</sup> ‘There is No Such Thing as a Free Market.’ *Rethinking Economics*. Accessed August 14<sup>th</sup>, 2025. <https://www.rethinkeconomics.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/09/23things-24-33.pdf>

<sup>30</sup> For example in the lecture ‘Freedom of a Forced Choice’, especially from around the 11-minute mark. (Žižek, S. ‘Freedom of a Forced Choice.’ Lecture delivered at the Faculty of Fine Arts, University of Porto, Portugal. November 22<sup>nd</sup>, 2014. YouTube. Channel: Ippolit Belinski. Uploaded January 26<sup>th</sup>, 2017. Accessed February 3<sup>rd</sup>, 2026. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=dB1pv4eF0xw&t=671s>)

<sup>31</sup> Beckert, S. *Capitalism: A Global History*. Penguin Press. New York. 2025. p. 158

### Power Imbalances, Domination, and Monopolies Under Anarcho-Capitalism

As we hinted at previously, the best and quickest way to be successful in *Quasimorph* is to cleverly manipulate the market in your favour, exploiting it by concentrating your efforts on working for one or two corporations rather than taking on contracts for several. Because there would be even less regulatory intervention than there is under state capitalism, this would mean that its economic market is even more subject to potential manipulation by those who have the capital, resources, and power to do so. *Quasimorph* naturally pushes you into a position where you have to exploit the cracks in an economic market for success, where you have to single out allies and decide to go against others. So not only does it testify to the impossibility of a truly free and uncoercive capitalist market, it also makes the case that there is no market free from manipulation by malevolent actors with the power and capital to back it up. Defenders of anarcho-capitalism or more stringent forms of free-market capitalism portray the market as an entity that will naturally provide checks and balances on excess and oppression if its freedom is maximized. As Rothbard characteristically reiterates, “the workings of the voluntary principle and of the free market lead inexorably to freedom, prosperity, harmony, efficiency, and order.” (Rothbard 2009, 1025) The freer a market is, the fairer it will also be, and the more it will naturally curb excesses and the growth of oppression, tyrannies, and monopolies.

But this idea is undermined by the fact that, as the player character in *Quasimorph*, advancing your position and succeeding *depends* on your ability to manipulate the market in your favour, by intervening in it to destabilize your chosen opponents to the benefit of your chosen allies. This is how corporations act in the modern capitalist world, and have acted for decades. But the installation of an ancap system, in the world of *Quasimorph*, seems to have done nothing to assuage this fact, and has arguably made it easier to do because of the lack of centralized authority systems, such as the police and international law. There is no reason why, under anarcho-capitalism, corporations could not pool their resources to increase their power, accumulation, and dominance at the expense of their chosen enemies. And they could do so by manipulating the market because no capitalist market is truly ‘free’ from this type of intervention, much less a totally unregulated one.

If the free market could be manipulated and exploited by the wealthiest operators in society, it follows that they could consolidate power and effect a system of domination over a people – and there would be no centralized regulatory or punitive system in place to stop them. Even private police companies would have the incentive to work with oppressive entities rather than against them if the economic benefit was greater. What anarcho-capitalism proposes is to free the capitalist market from the tyranny of the state, removing all state regulation, coercion, checks and balances on the private sphere. But under capitalism, it is possible for private companies to translate their wealth and resources into increased power, increased wealth, increased rate of accumulation, and increased political influence. Removing all states and all centralized systems of justice, law, and security while keeping the capitalist system would hand the most powerful private forces even more power and freedom to do this than they have already. To think that none of them would use it to try and increase their power and domination is naïve, and to think the free market would naturally stop them from doing so borders on fantastical.

In *Quasimorph*'s economic world, wild inequalities persist because the system favours the wealthiest players in it at the expense of everybody else. Corporations illicitly tip the scales in their favour over their opponents because they have the capital and influence to do so, which ordinary people lack. Because of these structural imbalances, tyrannies could easily form under ancap conditions, and *Quasimorph*'s world reflects this fact. People are not freer in this world, they are in fact brutally dominated by corporations even more than they would have been under state capitalism because there are now no laws or regulations to limit its most damaging effects. Some corporations dominate entire planets and even use human tissue in the generation of electricity, which it then sells for profit. This means that, in *Quasimorph*, monopolies are also easily able to form under anarcho-capitalist conditions. The corporations with the most power seem to have been able to get into that position because they perform a function that its world desperately needs: weapons, prisons, chemicals, communication technologies, etc. These corporations leverage their position to become the dominant forces in that market, effectively snuffing out their competition and becoming a monopoly.

But this presents another grave problem for anarcho-capitalism because another one of its supposed benefits is that it would either remove the possibility of monopolies forming, or

significantly limit their damage to the point where it would not pose a problem. Monopolies are often thought of poorly by defenders of capitalism because they stifle free-market competition. Monopolies involve one company getting so powerful they basically take control of their corner of the market, so they have no longer have incentive to improve their products and services because they have no genuine competitors which could outperform them. For anarcho-capitalism, one of the evils of the state is that it is effectively a monopoly over a particular territory in terms of security and other public services, as well as violence and force. So if only the state is allowed to offer public services and they suppress anyone else's capacity to compete with them, there is no free-market competition which would give it incentive to improve. The outcome of state monopolies, as Friedman says, is "low quality services at an exorbitant price." (Friedman 2014, 80)

Remarkably, Rothbard argues that genuine monopolies do not occur naturally in free-market capitalism. Rather,

monopoly is a grant of special privilege by the State, reserving a certain area of production to one particular individual or group. Entry into the field is prohibited to others and this prohibition is enforced by the gendarmes of the State.

(Rothbard 2009, 669)

For Rothbard, genuine natural monopolies can only occur when private companies are given special dispensations, permissions, aid, and otherwise preferential treatment by states that allow them to gain power, restrict their competition, and become a monopoly. Monopolies are therefore a product of state coercion, an instance of states leveraging political power to influence the market in a way that benefits them and their political/economic allies. Monopolies have the potential to be exploited for political power, using economic power and one's place in the market to influence governments, creating power imbalances and hierarchies that can destabilize markets and countries. Without the state, however, this would not be possible.<sup>32</sup>

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<sup>32</sup> Friedman adopts a more moderate position than Rothbard on the question of monopolies, but both agree that monopolies would not be a problem for anarcho-capitalism: "although [natural monopolies] occasionally exist under institutions of laissez faire, [they] do not seriously interfere with the workings of the market. The methods government uses to control such monopolies do far more damage than the monopolies themselves." (Friedman 2014, 31)

*Quasimorph*'s economic order shows that, on the contrary, monopolies can form under anarcho-capitalist conditions because if a market can be manipulated by those with the most power, there is no reason to suppose that they could not manipulate it enough to form a monopoly. Nevertheless, Rothbard is quite close to an important insight here, which will lead us onto *Quasimorph*'s final line of critique of anarcho-capitalism: that it is conceptually confused in its assumptions about the state, and if implemented would forfeit any genuine claim to being anarchistic because *de facto* coercive state power would persist under its proposed conditions.

### The Persistence of *De Facto* State Power Under Anarcho-Capitalism

Rothbard is adamant that the accumulation of power and market dominance necessary for a monopoly is only possible with state intervention. However, the existence of the state is actually paramount to the formation of capitalism itself as an economic system, as Beckert explains well:

No noneconomic institution mattered more [in the development of capitalism] than the state, that ensemble of institutions that govern, tax, wage war, regulate society, and adjudicate conflict in myriad ways. [...] The accumulation of privately controlled capital in a world of commodities in turn depends on the powerful presence of the state in economic life. Because capitalism is conceptually unimaginable without the state (while at the same time producing states of unprecedented scale and scope), the state itself is part of the very definition of capitalism, even though the precise forms the state takes have shifted quite dramatically over the past centuries and also vary between different countries.

(Beckert 2025, 28, 32)

Capitalism only became and stayed the globally dominant force it is with constant help and dispensations from state power. Yet anarcho-capitalism proposes, for capitalism's sake, to remove the very thing that allowed the capitalist order to be. This points to a conceptual confusion at the heart of anarcho-capitalism which *Quasimorph* understands well. Anarcho-capitalism is conceptually confused because, although it professes to be, it is not truly anarchistic. Under anarcho-capitalism, coercive state power would persist *de facto* in the form of the most powerful and dominant corporations who dominate particular territories, resulting in many smaller states rather than a few large ones. Sabatini voices this criticism as follows:

Rothbard's claim as an anarchist is quickly voided when it is shown that he only wants an end to the public state. In its place he allows countless private states, with each person supplying their own police force, army, and law, or else purchasing these services from capitalist vendors.<sup>33</sup>

But anarchism wants to abandon the state *per se*, which would also mean any structure of coercive domination over a people that strongly resembles and functions like a state. Under anarcho-capitalism, such a structure would very much be possible. In fact, it is highly likely that the private market competitors would effectively function as a system of many *de facto* states. Multiple different companies would compete to perform state functions and enforce their decisions on the public living in their territory - which is the same thing a state does, it would just be done privately. In privatizing all the same functions and services a state would perform, anarcho-capitalism abolishes the private state, but diffuses the state as a coercive structure into the private sphere. Under anarcho-capitalism, private legal and judicial firms would offer their services to group of people who agree to abide by their laws, and when someone breaks these agreed-upon laws, a private security or police firm would presumably be hired to punish rule-breakers. This would be a system of organized coercion resembling a small, localized state – and there would be many such states in different territories under anarcho-capitalism, rather than a few centralized, public ones. If this is anarchism, it is certainly not anarchism in the traditional sense.

Problems of differences private legal, judicial, and security systems also seem rather inevitable under anarcho-capitalism. When one private security firm's rules differ with another's in the same or an adjacent territory, it seems likely that violence could ensue, which would effectively be a war between two state-like systems on a small scale. And if private companies ever became powerful enough to control a significant amount of territory, there is no centralized system of international law preventing them from engaging in large-scale armed conflict with their competitors, or for committing atrocities against them. This plays out noticeably in *Quasimorph's* economic world. Major corporations end up having significantly more power than the others, and have effective monopolies in the things they specialize in, whether it's

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<sup>33</sup> Sabatini, P. *Libertarianism: Bogus Anarchy*. Archived at The Anarchist Library. Originally published in 1995. Accessed August 13<sup>th</sup> 2025. <https://theanarchistlibrary.org/library/peter-sabatini-libertarianism-bogus-anarchy>

chemicals, weapons, cargo transport, or prisons. They also end up having power over certain parts of the solar system, with entire planets under their control. If we conceive of the state as anarchism does, as a structure of coercive domination which unjustly takes a monopoly of security and violence over a territory, then not only does *Quasimorph*'s anarcho-capitalist world have a state, it has many.

### Conclusion: A Seeming Change

I have argued that the roguelike extraction shooter *Quasimorph* mounts a serious critique of anarcho-capitalist ideology through its narrative, worldbuilding, and procedural rhetoric on at least three discernible fronts:

- 1) *The impossibility of free and non-coercive capitalist markets.*
- 2) *The inevitability of monopolies and asymmetric power dynamics under anarcho-capitalism.*
- 3) *The inevitable persistence of de facto state authority under anarcho-capitalism.*

It therefore belongs to the rich lineage of digital games (such as *Bioshock*, *Deus Ex*, and others) whose worlds, mechanics, and narratives engage in sophisticated, lettered representations and critiques of libertarian and capitalist ideologies, allowing players to come to an understanding of these systems by putting them in playable form. *Quasimorph* lets the player come to its critical understanding of anarcho-capitalism with a relatively light and open developmental touch, in which the player must navigate its system, experience its contradictions for themselves, and learn to navigate it. The way the player can navigate this system is reflective of points which undermine some of the most crucial conceptual aspects of anarcho-capitalist ideology.

*Quasimorph*'s vision of an anarcho-capitalist future is a bleak hellscape in which the worst parts of capitalism continue to thrive, unfettered by the limited protections and regulatory measures of democratic states. It suggests that an anarcho-capitalist future would maintain all the inequalities and coercive hierarchies of capitalism while removing the limited protections afforded by democratic state structures. The world changes form but retains its underlying logic. This means that, arguably, *Quasimorph*'s critique of anarcho-capitalism is most neatly summed up by the actual word 'quasimorph' itself, which suggests *something that has only*



*seemingly changed*, which appears to have changed but has in fact not changed in essence. *Quasimorph*'s critique of anarcho-capitalism is that it would represent only a seeming change from capitalism, only seemingly addressing its structural injustices at best, and exacerbating them dramatically at worst. The inequalities and power imbalances characteristic of capitalism would still persist, markets would still be coercive and subject to intervention, and corporations would still be able to translate capital into increased power and monopolies. States (as structures of coercive dominance and monopolies of violence over particular territories) would continue to exist, but in privatized form – so anarcho-capitalism would not really be anarchist, anyway. Economic markets would still be able to be manipulated by those clever, resourceful, or powerful enough to do so – indeed, this would likely be even easier to do without the regulatory interventions of democratic states.

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